

Black Crappie

Pomoxis nigromaculatus

Find the school, then hold the depth

Recognize it

Deep, compressed silver-olive panfish with irregular dark speckles scattered across the sides.

Body	Seven or eight dorsal spines; mottling has no orderly vertical bars.
Mouth/fins	Large upturned mouth; dorsal and anal fins are nearly equal in outline.
Confusion	White crappie usually shows vertical bars and five or six dorsal spines.

Lake role

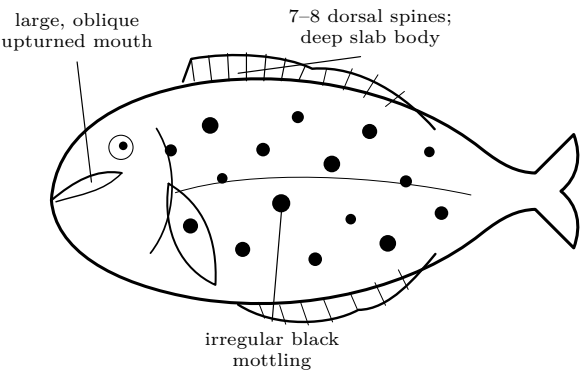
Where it belongs

Clear-water weeds, wood, basin edges, and suspended schools near prey.

Food and season

Insects and small fish; shallow near spawning cover, then edge or suspend.

Identification plate



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test protected new weeds in spring; later scan outside weed edges and open-water prey.
North	Test wood, weed pockets, and the first break near protected spawning water.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

1. **Slip float.** Hang a small jig or live bait just above marked fish; adjust depth before changing color.
2. **Slow vertical jig.** Use a light plastic or hair jig and pause; keep it above the school.
3. **Stop rule.** If no marks, bites, or bait appear in ten minutes, move and search rather than decorating empty water.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Use wet hands and a small rubber net. Support the body; do not lift a large fish by the lip alone.

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Prefer abundant hand-size fish; release unusually large adults if a meal is already secured.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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